Compare justify evaluate

Questions that deepen reasoning

Use comparison, justification and evaluation prompts when students need to explain a relationship or make a judgement. Ensure they have the knowledge and criteria required to reason well.

How to do it well

1 Choose the thinking demand. Decide whether students are identifying a contrast, defending a claim or judging quality against a criterion.

2 Prepare the cases. Select examples close enough to require attention to the important difference.

3 State the criteria. Clarify which knowledge, evidence or performance feature should inform the response.

4 Protect preparation. Give silent time to form a claim and supporting reason, then use talk or writing to refine it.

5 Probe and transfer. Ask what would change the judgement and test the same criterion in a fresh case.

What this sounds like

“Compare the two methods for this task. Which is more efficient, and what evidence supports that judgement? When might the other method be preferable?”

Classroom example. In Art, pupils compare two compositions against a taught criterion. They identify a feature, explain its effect and justify which better meets the purpose. A changed brief then asks whether the judgement would change. The evaluation draws on disciplinary knowledge rather than a preference for whichever work initially looks more attractive.

Top tips that make the technique work

Make comparison focused. Specify the feature or relationship to compare rather than asking for every possible similarity and difference.

Require evidence. “I prefer this one” becomes useful when linked to a criterion or example.

Choose genuinely comparable cases. If one is obviously poor, the judgement may demand little thought.

Ask for an alternative. Students can explain what would make the other option defensible.

Rehearse before public answers. A written claim and evidence or structured partner exchange can improve the precision of the response.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
State the criterion and demand a reason.	Vague preferences without disciplinary evidence.
Use taught knowledge to support the judgement.	An evaluation task before students know what quality means.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation. Some links support part of this guide rather than the whole technique.

DistillED - Process Questions | Barton - Plan follow-up questions in advance